approved laboratory to ensure that it plays fair within the rules. It is difficult to set up this state capacity.

There are other countries where this state capacity is present. As an example, the US was traditionally a large market for such devices, and the US Federal Communications Commission (FCC) does such testing. As the US market is an important one for any global devices vendor, these vendors generally obtain a US FCC approval. It is, then, possible for a regulator to free-ride on this testing process. For example, an Indian regulator can require US FCC approval for devices that are to be sold in India.

This free-riding works if and only if the policy framework for spectrum utilization in India is the same as that in the US. For example, this means that India should allocate spectrum for unrestricted use in a way that is similar to the Industrial, Scientific and Medical (ISM) bands used in the US.

Summing up

Many policy notes in India are written by reviewing what is done in a few other countries, and patching together some plausible-sounding policy proposal for India. This approach works poorly. Enlightenment values port across the world, but tangible policy designs do not.

We must go from a ‘thin description’ of what is done elsewhere in the world to a ‘thick description’, an incentive-based understanding of why officials and private persons behave as they do in advanced countries. [3]

A great deal of what happens in advanced economies relies on an ‘invisible infrastructure’ of state apparatus and checks and balances that is not immediately within view when focusing on a narrow problem of policy. The US SEC does certain things right because the United States Constitution establishes certain protections, but when we focus on how the US SEC works, these foundations tend to be overlooked.

To do public policy in the Indian context requires envisioning how a proposed design of an intervention or a government organization will work